

A Clear and Present Danger

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Hashing

Day 1: explain git.

Day 2: the rest

What is Hashing?

A cryptographic hash function is a one way mathematical function that maps data of an arbitrary size to a bit array of fixed size. The output bit array is commonly called a hash or digest. -Wikipedia

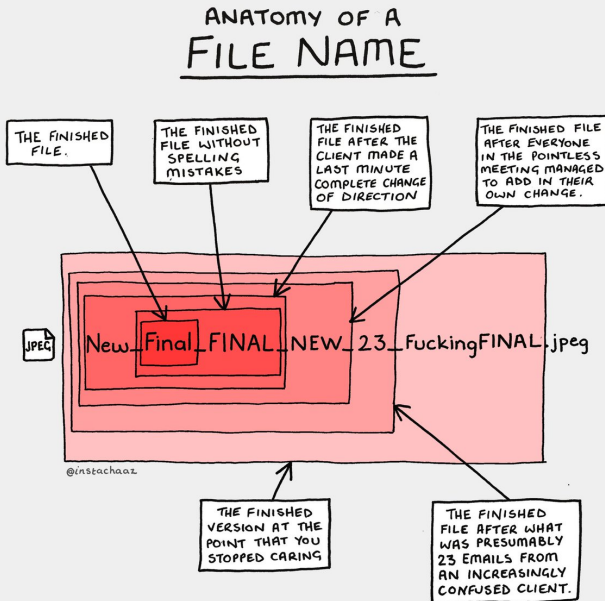
Key tenets of a hash algorithm:

1. **Fast**, must not take a lot of resources or time to compute (we will violate this rule later...)
2. **Irreversible**, must not be able to retrieve the original data from the resulting hash (one way transformation)
3. **Deterministic**, for the same input value, a hash function must always provide the same output
4. A small change to the input should result in large change to the hash value (**avalanche effect**)

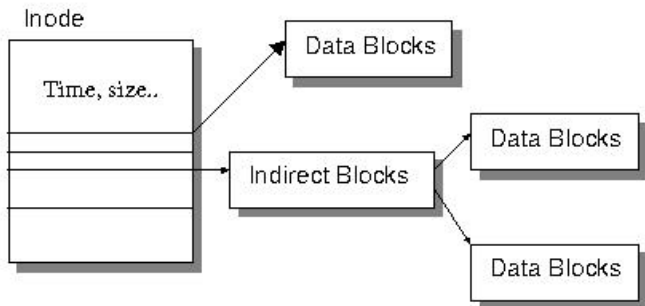
A fancy algorithm that converts a variable length input data to a fixed length output data with the following constraints:

- same input == same output
- different input == **MASSIVE** likelihood of different output
- output data reveals **NO** information about the input data
- must be **collision resistant**

File names



File System Metadata



Again

- same input == same output
- different input == **MASSIVE** likelihood of different output
- output data reveals **NO** information about the input data
- must be **collision resistant**

What is a “collision”?

Ship



Figure 3: Ship

Plane



Hashing algorithms

Hashing Algorithm	Hash size (bits)	Hash size (hex length)	Collision-resistant
MD5	128	32	no
sha256	256	64	yes
sha512	512	128	yes
NTLM	128	32	no

Note: "Collision-resistant" should be "no known collisions currently" in the above chart

What is Hashing used for

- verify the integrity of data (block chain, downloads, git commits, secure software)
- digital signatures
- as a part of verifying a given users *Authenticity* (a part of *Authentication*)
- Proof-o'-work (mining, defense against Denial of Service)

Follow along (in bash) for some data science fun

What is the difference between the following:

- `echo "Hi!"`
- `printf "Hi!"` <— Hint: Use this one for the exercise

What do the following do?

- `|` The pipe character
- `awk -F ',' '{ print $1 }'` Hint: pipe the cat output of `quiz-data.csv` into this
- `grep <string>`

Now about the quiz data, can we reverse our hash?

What are some common (semi) unique identifiers for people?

- campus W-number
- campus UID
- Social Security Number
- First initial Last name combo i.e. MKijowski

Don't believe everything you read on the internet.

Attacks on hashes

- Brute force: hash everything (worst case scenario)
- Pass the hash: an authenticating system accepts hashes, and you have them
- Dictionary attack: you have a dictionary of likely input data used to compute hashes
- Rainbow table: you have a dictionary of pre-computed hashes and known input data
- Collision: you guess/compute *different* data that computes to the same hash value

Nonce and salt

Both added to data prior to the hashing function to increase uniqueness. Used for different reasons though.

- Salts increase complexity and prevent several known attacks on hash values (dictionary and rainbow table attacks)
- Nonces are unique (number used only once) and are used to prevent replay attacks (cannot use same nonce) and in proof of work
- These do not increase any guarantee of integrity!!

Key stretching

Suppose an attacker has the salts and hash values and can guess at the original data used. . .

To make things harder for an attacker, we can simply apply the hashing algorithm to the output of the first.

Do this multiple times to *stretch* (lengthen) the time it takes to attack the hash using common dictionary attacks.

Proof of Work

Proof of an amount of work prior to participating.

Created to reduce email spam.

Example: include a nonce that hashes to X number of leading 0's
(see Hashcash)

Lets talk lab 1

- 10 commits == 10 points
- style == 10 points
- task 1 == 50 points (15 points for salted quiz data set)
- task 2 == 50 points (15 points for coins)

Lab 1 continued

- `data/` : folder containing data for use in this lab
- `miner/` : folder for your mining code
- `LAB1-INSTRUCTIONS.md` : markdown file containing lab instructions
- `README.md` : markdown file for your answers and lab writeup. This is the file I am grading (as well as other requested files)
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- Answers/ responses should be on a new line and not require scrolling around the page (be careful of code blocks).
- Check the style guide in the course repository for more details!!

Recap

Hashing gives you: fixed-size, deterministic, one-way fingerprints of data — with the avalanche effect making them collision-resistant (*for now*).

- **Integrity & auth** — verify data hasn't changed, prove you know a secret
- **Attacks** — brute force, dictionary, rainbow table, pass-the-hash, collision
- **Defenses** — salt (kills precomputed tables) + nonce (kills replay) + stretching (slows brute force)
- **Passwords & files** — fast hash for integrity, *slow* hash (bcrypt/scrypt/Argon2) for secrets

Now go build a miner and don't leak your coins.

Anatomy of a git commit

Homework

- Research some effective and ineffective password strategies (google it. . .)
- Make a new Linux/WSL user with a weak password (please do not use one of the top 10 passwords)
- Copy the above users weak password hash (their corresponding line in `/etc/shadow`) and submit to Pilot.
 - It should look something like this:
`mynewuser2:$y$j9T$hBy.nN91qFxXxCMP...`
- Get started on your lab!!!